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Dear Admission Committee,

REF: RECOMMENDATION FOR SWAIB OKITA OUMA

I am honored to have been Swaib's teacher of English Language and Literature. He made my class exciting by raising high-level discussions; more so in our essay writing paper. I could always count on him to bring a different, well-thought-out view to our class conversations. I have fond memories of his presentation of the text When The Sun Goes Down and other stories when he eloquently made his well-researched talk of *Tillie Olsen's 'I Stand Here Ironing'*, one of the more difficult set texts to comprehend. He has a knack for critiquing author's works, logically comparing writing styles, thematic concerns, and plot settings to formulate his conclusion. In a bid to grow this skill in himself and others, he revived the Writer's Club that had been dormant for a while. He used his money to publish daily articles, dubbed 'Articles of the Day', that creatively articulated a fruit blend of societal issues, creating awareness, and shaping the way of thinking of everyone who read them. This ignited conversations around all topics and fueled students to openly debate national issues. In the same vein, months after leaving school, he founded his blog (www.artsiva.com) that seeks to accomplish this goal on a global platform.

Swaib loves literature and he strived to pass his knowledge by devoting an hour to take other students through the set texts- and other disciplines- every day after the evening preps. He stepped up in times when I was held up to take the class through English lessons. Later on, when I asked why he went beyond his duty in this way, he remarkably said: "I feel responsible for my classmate's grades. In school, we compete amongst ourselves and it is a great feeling when you become the best but what matters eventually, in our education system, is the final paper. I will feel guilty if I succeed alone knowing that I did nothing to improve the grades and the lives of those around me." This has stood out as something very profound to me; a true show of his character. It is no wonder that in his last year, when the administration was tasked with choosing a student to play the role of "the student with the best character", in an interview with the national broadcasting station KBC, in partnership with "*be the change campaign*" on integrity, only one name instantly popped in our minds.

I mentored him in the World Scholar's Cup 2016, which incorporates team debates, scholar's bowl, collaborative writing and scholar's challenge. This program serves to celebrate learning by bringing several subjects together to help scholars see the bigger picture while addressing serious global issues. It teaches learners the spirit of teamwork and problem solving so that they may be dependable. In the East Africa round, Swaib emerged the best student in essay writing and the third best student overall, winning 21 awards cumulatively. His team proceeded to the Global Round in Bangkok, Thailand, where he won three awards. They qualified for the Tournament of Champions at Yale University but they could not proceed due to financial constraints. As a team

leader, he pushed his teammates to bring into their study discussions foreign students so that they would benefit from their diverse cultures and world perspectives.

While studying for his final examinations, he organized the *Tisa Tisa Festival*, a social event that brought together students to celebrate life. I must confess that if it were any other student, I would have feared that his performance in the final examinations would be compromised. I would later learn that their sponsor bailed out on them a day to the event. Anyone else would have been distraught, but not Swaib. He inspired his team to pick themselves up and move on with the plan in spite of the setback. He chose to take the risk. That, to me, was very brave. He never gives up and I think that Africa and the world needs more leaders with his temperament to drive growth and see ideas through for the betterment of humanity.

I am truly honored to have been his teacher and mentor. He has made, and continues to make, the best out of every opportunity presented to him while giving back to those around him in equal measure. I can affirm that through the four years, he stood out as the kind of person to pursue his ambitions with an astonishing single-mindedness; an attribute that makes him a force to reckon with in whatever he sets his mind to do. It therefore affords me great pleasure to unreservedly recommend Swaib Okita Ouma as a young man best suited to pursue his choice program in your prestigious institute where he will be a most valuable asset.

Yours faithfully,

Evelyn A Kibisu
Head of Department
English Language and Literature

